

ANI

SHOW OF HANDS
INDIA bloc leaders Uddhav Thackeray, Rahul Gandhi, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Sharad Pawar at an MVA rally in Mumbai, Nov. 7

and constitutional values, themes she has championed in her political campaigns.

Priyanka's arrival presents both an opportunity and a challenge for the Congress. Having her alongside other Gandhi family members in Parliament could attract further scrutiny from opponents like the BJP, which has long accused the Congress of being a family-centric entity. However, her ability to verbalise grassroots issues and craft a compelling narrative could help mitigate some of these criticisms. Often compared to her grandmother Indira Gandhi for her eloquence and knack of connecting personally with voters, Priyanka has the potential to reshape the Congress's public persona.

Needed: A New Narrative

The Congress's inability to craft cohesive local narratives supported by an efficient organisational structure has been its bane in state elections like Haryana and Maharashtra. In both states, the party leaned heavily on broad national issues, such as "saving the Constitution" and the caste census—strategies that fell flat. To remain relevant in state contests, the party must pivot from national narratives to addressing grassroots-level issues that resonate locally. For instance, the caste census plank was a muddled one in Haryana and Maharashtra due to the dominant Jats and Marathas seeking OBC status, with existing beneficiary castes ranged against them. The other overarching national narrative, such as protecting the Constitution, also lost traction, particularly after the BJP's seat tally went down to 240 in the Lok Sabha.

Rahul's campaign approach also reflects this disconnect. His heightened focus on the Adani controversy ended up creating embarrassment within the alliance, thus muddying any chance of fetching coherent results. Senior ally Sharad Pawar expressed discomfort with this strategy, emphasising the impracticality of hinging a campaign on one issue. This was compounded by Congress leaders like Revanth Reddy and Ashok Gehlot publicly associating with Gautam Adani.

Factionalism has also been a persistent issue. In Maharashtra, senior leaders like Nana Patole, Prithviraj Chavan and Balasaheb Thorat pursued conflicting agendas, leaving the state unit rudderless. In Haryana, Bhupinder Hooda became too domineering over the campaign, sidelining key figures like Kumari Selja and Randeep Singh Surjewala.

The Road to Revival

To reclaim its lost glory, the Congress must return to its fundamentals. It needs to reinforce its grassroots presence, overhaul its organisational structure, enforce accountability, and craft a narrative that goes beyond merely criticising PM Modi and the BJP. The party's dependence on a personality-driven campaigns, anti-incumbency factors, and fleeting issues has proven ineffective so far.

Its inability to manage booth-level operations effectively, especially in direct contests with the BJP, has been a recurring issue. State elections demand direct engagement with local issues and electorates, which top-down campaigns fail to achieve. The Congress must shed its over-reliance on the Gandhis and adopt a bottom-up approach, empowering strong state leaders and credible local faces to establish voter trust.

Recognising this need, the party has committed to a significant organisational revamp after the Delhi election. At the Udaipur Chintan Shivir in 2022 and the Raipur Plenary in 2023, the Congress pinned down its challenges and identified potential remedies. The goal is not merely to replace individuals but to establish accountability, create space for younger leaders and empower grassroots units with greater decision-making authority. Building an accountable, robust organisational structure that cannot be manipulated by a few will be key to this.

The Congress now stands at a critical juncture, caught between the expectations of its allies in the INDIA bloc and the burden of its own internal dysfunctions. The party faces a decisive test: prove its worth as the anchor of Opposition politics or risk irrelevance in the evolving political landscape. ■